at Saint-Malo, on the Brittany coast.[4]

He had visions of a great and glorious war against the French enemy, but after five months he still hadn't gotten out of Brittany. Inexperience, empty pockets, and the prospect of fierce French opposition stalled the English army at the southern border: "The king of England all this time," writes Roger of Wendover, "was lying with his army at the city of Nantes, doing nothing except spending his money." In October, recognizing the impossibility of fighting any farther into the lost lands, Henry III gave up and went home. Not long after, the Count of Brittany reversed himself and became, once more, the vassal of Louis IX.[5]

Neither of the young kings had distinguished himself. Henry III spent the next few years trying to appease his own barons, who were annoyed both by his autocratic manner (his first move, as soon as he got back to London, was to demand that they all ante up scutage to pay for the unsuccessful campaign) and by his propensity to offer favors to the French. And Louis IX, relying on Blanche to keep his own unhappy barons in line, found himself forced to yield to most of their demands to keep peace.

ACROSS THE WATER south of England, across the mountains west of France, the kings of Spain were having much better fortune.

